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COMPANY DEEP-DIVE

Vice President at Zendesk Believes Intercom's Focus on Fin AI Bot Is a Smart Strategy Amid Industry Consolidation Potential

DATE PUBLISHED	INTERVIEW DATE	EXPERT PERSPECTIVE	ANALYST PERSPECTIVE	PRIMARY COMPANY
21 Jan 2026	23 Oct 2025	Competitor	Investor-Led (Buy-Side)	FIN

OTHER COMPANIES

CRM

SMART SUMMARY

Summary

The interview covers the structure of the customer support software market, Intercom's positioning and focus on its Fin AI bot, integration and pricing dynamics, and potential industry consolidation scenarios.

EXPERT BACKGROUND

- Vice President of Enterprise Data and Analytics at a leading customer support platform provider, with four years of experience overseeing data engineering, business analytics, and AI/ML teams, and a prior background in data analytics and mathematics.

EXPERT SENTIMENT

- The expert believes **Intercom's strategy to focus on its Fin AI bot is smart given its resource constraints compared to larger competitors, and that specialization is likely to be more successful** than trying to compete as a full platform provider.
- The expert sees potential for industry consolidation, with the possibility of Intercom being acquired by a larger player like Salesforce, but does not expect an imminent exit or IPO for Intercom, suggesting a timeline of 2025-2027 for such events.

TAKEAWAYS

- The customer support software space is segmented into full platform providers (like Zendesk, Salesforce Service Cloud, Freshdesk), CCaaS providers (like Genesys, Five9), and specialized solution providers (like Intercom with its Fin bot).
- Intercom's primary focus and fastest-growing business is its Fin AI bot, which is often used in conjunction with larger platforms rather than as a standalone suite.
- Integration capabilities, breadth of channels, and industry-specific features are key differentiators for platform providers; **Intercom is seen as lacking in integrations and voice capabilities compared to larger competitors**.
- **Pricing models in the space are shifting from seat-based to resolution-based, with Intercom's Fin bot charging per resolved ticket, often undercutting competitors on price**.
- Intercom tends to serve smaller to mid-sized businesses, with some presence in financial services, while larger enterprises and industries like retail and airlines are more commonly served by larger platform providers.

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Expert Bio

Vice President, Enterprise Data and Analytics at Zendesk. The expert is responsible for building, maturing, and running the technical infrastructure, data platform, Insights, visualizations, capabilities, skills, and performance to support a rapidly growing, data-driven organisation. Prior to Zendesk expert was a Chief Executive Officer in Start-Up - Retail and consumer technology. Reporting to the Board of Directors. Responsibilities include setting the company’s overall strategy, leading the executive team, making key decisions, managing operations, representing the company to investors and stakeholders, and ensuring the company achieves its financial and strategic goals.

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The expert can speak to or has implemented advanced analytics, AI/ML at scale, enterprise data strategy, cloud data platforms, and customer insights across sectors including technology, retail, and healthcare.

Interview Transcript

Client 00:00:00
Thank you for taking the time to speak with me today about Intercom. To start off, could you please give us a quick overview of your background and experience in this space?

Expert 00:00:08
I look after enterprise AI analytics and data, Zendesk. That's all data engineering or business analytics and BI. About 20% of all AI/ML teams. I've been with Zendesk about four years, and then prior to that I've had various roles mainly focusing on data analytics and I'm a mathematician by training.

Client 00:00:31
That's very helpful. Maybe I'd like to start off with getting your thoughts on the space in general. The customer support space has a lot of different players. To me, at least it seems to be quite commoditized. Maybe I'm wrong about that, but at least that's the sense I get from diligence that we've done. I want to get your thoughts on what the space looks like, is it commoditized or not and who are the leading players and why?

Expert 00:00:55
One level it is, but the way we see is we break it down into sections. There are, you would call it platform providers and that's ours, Zendesk and then it's Service Cloud from Salesforce and then Freshdesk from Freshworks. Those are full platform software providers. You can plug and play, and you've got a solution that provides all you need for contact center out of a box.

We've got CCaaS providers that provide voice as well. That's the Genesys of the world that sit at that space. That's a fully outsourced solution with the people included. That's a slightly different business. You got Five9 and all the other CCaaS providers in that bucket. That's a slightly different business because they're renting people.

They have software, but their software is not as sophisticated as that from Salesforce or ours or Freshworks and generally doesn't have AI-embedded, for example. We've people who provide one part of the pie and that would be where Intercom sit. People will buy Fin on its own and then they may buy Zendesk as well. You can't just have the bot.

You then need something that manages the tickets and provides the other aspects of a contact center software solution. People do buy that. You've got Decagon and Sierra. Those guys fall in that space as well. You've got people who build their own and that they're using some more generic platform. This would be like Microsoft 365.

Even people can do stuff with Google plus their own OpenAI that thing. For example, Karla built that and then Google tries to do that as well, although they also buy our software. Some large technology businesses are trying to build their own using standard technology platform solutions. That is the overall big breakdown of the space as we see it. I'm happy to get more specific about Intercom, if that is helpful to you.

Client 00:02:49
I think that would be helpful. This makes sense. I think what we're trying to understand is Intercom is providing one part of the pie. Especially I think it's focused on its Fin AI bot, as they call it, Fin and AI agents. Can you tell us a little bit more about that? Is that primarily what they're focused on? How does it all work? Who is buying this solution and are they using it together with Zendesk and other solutions? Who is using Intercom and why?

Expert 00:03:20
To be fair, they also provide Intercom customer service suite. You can buy that from them and then you can combine Fin with that. Customer service doesn't contain all of the bells and whistles that you might want from your reporting suite. For example, it doesn't really have reporting. There are reasons people don't buy customer service. People do buy it, but that is not a big competitor in the market and it is not what Intercom are focused on.

Intercom are killing it with Fin. They're focused on Fin. I don't think they issue public breakdowns of their revenue exactly how much they're doing with Fin, but **that's the fastest growing** part of their business by far. This is what they're focused on. People will quite often buy Fin as the bot and then Zendesk or Service Cloud or some other software as the platform.

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Client 00:04:07

Can you maybe just help me understand in what cases is a customer buying Fin in the front end and then using a Zendesk platform as the back end versus someone buying the entire Intercom suite altogether? The reason I ask that is, it comes down to my thesis on the space being commoditized.

What we're trying to figure out is Intercom has been around for a while. Zendesk had an exit, it was acquired, it was taken private. We're trying to understand given Fin's growth and given this new focus, and **it seems to be riding all the AI tailwinds**, how should we be thinking about Intercom in context of customers, in context of who's using it and in context of the broader market.

Expert 00:04:48

If I look at Intercom versus Zendesk, which is the easiest comparison for me to make. Fins workspace has an annotation, reporting I've talked about. **Zendesk is very good** at seamlessly integrating all channels, different types of messaging. Whereas Intercom, all of the channels aren't really integrated, and they are all paid add-ons. If you want WhatsApp as a channel you have to pay separately for it.

Isn't natively integrated into the suite and that is a big channel for Europe, for example. On the integration side, Zendesk has a lot more integrations and they have a native. We also have we also build custom integrations for clients or there are lots of people who build those kinds of things. We probably have five or six times the number of integrations that Intercom has.

That is important for a lot of businesses. If you are an online retailer, then a Shopify integration or an integration with whatever inventory and delivery system is critical because the most common question you are going to get is where is my stuff? If you are an airline, we do quite a lot of airline business, you got to have the integration with your booking system.

I suspect Intercom's got Shopify integration, but they definitely don't have airline booking systems integrations. You cannot really operate without it. Otherwise, the support agent is going to have to come out of the support suite system, go to this other system, type in the customer details, try to retrieve the booking, go back.

It is just going to be a port and forget about Chinese AI to automate. Those integrations are surprisingly important. Intercom doesn't do voice and Zendesk does. Those things are things that people choose Zendesk over Intercom. Surprisingly often I would say people are then choosing Fin as a bot.

I think the total revenue of Intercom is $350 million or something. We're knocking on the door of $2 billion. It's a different scale of business. Service Cloud and Salesforce is bigger than us. They're different scales of business. We run into people who want to use the Fin bot and say it's better than our bot.

Client 00:06:57

Can you talk a little bit about Fin bot? What exactly is it like? Is it what I'm imagining? I go on a website, and I have some question about my stuff or where's my delivery or help me find something or whatever it may be. Am I thinking about this correctly? Fin is the chatbot that I'm seeing on a website and I'm asking it questions and it's interacting with me.

The data that's in the Fin agent, whether it's my details, whether it's the summary of the interaction, all of that. That stuff is saved and recorded in a platform like Zendesk or Salesforce when customers are using Fin combined with Zendesk. Is that the right way of thinking about it?

Expert 00:07:35

Correct. We provide an API integration for Fin, that customer can do this. They want to use Fin bot and we're okay. We prefer to use our bot, but of course we won't to force people to do that. There is an API integration and then it's passing data from Zendesk suite to the Fin bot and then on your messaging stream. When you open your customer support ticket, let's say it's mobile telephony.

I think we've got some customers who have Fin bot and Zendesk in mobile telephony. You might be asking questions like, "I saw your new plan advertised can you tell me about that? How does it compare with my current plan and can I switch over?" If that's something that the bot understands, then it will answer that for you. If it isn't, it'll pass you to an agent.

Provided there's an integration within Zendesk Suite and the operational systems of the mobile telephony provider, then the bot might say, "Would you like me to upgrade your plan for you? I can do that right now." If they say yes, it will handle that on the back end and the agents are getting more sophisticated.

The agent both from us and to some extent from Fin, although I'm not privy to exactly how the AI within Fin works, are becoming more agentic and goal orientated as opposed to workload. It used to be you'd run those bots, and you would write the workflow. You can still do that if you want to. These days the bots they're LLM powered and therefore you're giving a goal of the prompt and then without defining a workflow they're answering problems.

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Client 00:09:07
Got it. I understand that Zendesk provides API integration to Fin and Intercom probably does the same thing. Is the Fin AI agent, is it just better than the Zendesk chatbots? Why wouldn't a customer want to stay with one window when it comes to customer support? Why have two separate windows? That's what I'm a little bit confused about.

Expert 00:09:27
Largely they do. They're pretty close to being bigger than the whole of Intercom. People do largely choose to stay within the Zendesk system rather than run API and integrate with Fin. That happens more than the flip by quite a long way. I don't have the figures for Intercom, but I know there are also customers that decide to use.

They say, "Reporting doesn't really bother me. I'm just going to go into Fin for the whole thing." That happens too. There are a portion of customers who are convinced that the Zendesk suite is better than Intercom and they want a best of breed solution and therefore that's what they want to run with. That's not the norm.

That's the exception. It's a big enough exception that happens enough of the time for sizable business in Fin. The same is true with Salesforce. There's people running Fin with Service Cloud. Freshdesk I'm not so sure. I haven't heard of customers using Freshworks with Fin. I think because if you're choosing Freshworks you want the cheapest solution and Fin isn't cheap. I don't think that's common.

Client 00:10:31
I want to switch focus to pricing for a second. To me it sounds like a lot of companies including Intercom are shifting from seat-based pricing to more of a resolution based or an outcome-based pricing. I think I read somewhere that the Fin AI agent charges I think $0.99 or $1 for every resolved ticket.

What I'm trying to understand is how does Intercom actually measure the resolve ticket? Is it just that, the customer asked me a question and I was able to satisfy them without having to defer to a human agent. Is that when Intercom gets paid? How does that work?

Expert 00:11:05
In terms of pricing, Zendesk offers both. You can pay per seat, or you can pay per resolution or some mix of those. There's standard headline pricing around which I can tell you or you can look up on the website. We would have first offer resolutions basis pricing. Our headline on resolutions basis is $1.50 per resolution. Fin copied us and said, "We're going to $0.99 a resolution," which I'd done too if I were them. Not everyone placed headline pricing and there's then negotiation around those different things.

Client 00:11:38
Is it as simple as if I am a customer, I am interacting with whether it's the Zendesk or the Intercom chatbot and I'm able to get my question answered without being deferred to a human agent, then that counts as a resolution.

Expert 00:11:51
Yeah, or if it goes via copilot. Depending on the how the contract is on copilot they met that may also count as a resolution. Copilot is like the AI assistant for agents.

Client 00:12:03
I see.

Expert 00:12:04
We can include that in resolutions if you want. If not, it can be part of seat-based price.

Client 00:12:10
Got it. Is there a difference between the customers that are choosing Intercom versus Zendesk? Is Intercom more focused on small businesses, Zendesk more enterprise? Is there any sense around that?

Expert 00:12:21
Yes. I think on average they're probably smaller.

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Client 00:12:25

For Intercom?

Expert 00:12:26

Yeah. I think they got Atlassian. They've got some sizable customers as well. I think they do a little bit better in financial services. **We kill it in retail and manufacturing and airlines**.

Client 00:12:40

It seems like it's a mix. It's not like Intercom is focused on SMBs and Zendesk is enterprise. Is it fair to say that it's all a mix?

Expert 00:12:51

The people who do the best with a large enterprise is Salesforce. Both Intercom and us do better in the mid-sized business sector. There are a few industries where airlines and retail where we also very well in enterprise.

Client 00:13:05

I see.

Expert 00:13:05

Home Depot, a bunch of very large retail businesses.

Client 00:13:09

Having said all that, I think all the points you made probably don't deter me from my thesis which is space is commoditized and there are a lot of players. Where do you think the space goes from here? Is Intercom a standalone solution, or do you think it exists as part of broader platform? Would Zendesk acquire Intercom, would Salesforce also acquire Intercom? How should we be thinking about Intercom investment?

Expert 00:13:37

I think is their strategy to focus on Fin. If you look at all of their advertising is all Fin. They quite often don't even say Intercom, they just say Fin. I think their strategy is to focus on Fin as a bot solution. I think that's smart because they don't have the same resources as a Salesforce or even ours. If they stay really focused and specialized on bot, versus they spread their resources and try to build a reporting suite and all of the rest of the things they need to do.

I hope they do that. I think that will dilute their focus and they'll end up being a not very good version. I think their strategy is to focus on bot based on their public market. Otherwise, they'd be advertising Intercom more than they do. You could ask them. They probably have some public statements on that I haven't checked.

Client 00:14:26

Do you think Intercom eventually if they specialize on the bot, they're the best bot solution in the market? If Zendesk or Salesforce or another player acquires them, what do you think is the progression for the company?

Expert 00:14:38

We acquired a business called Ultimate, which was a bot specialist. We made an acquisition in that space, and we're developing our own bot platform. I think it's possible Salesforce would acquire them. I think **Service Cloud is a bit weak in that area**, that's a possibility. It's also quite a big business. That would be a big acquisition for us. It wouldn't be big for them.

Client 00:15:01

To the extent that you can disclose or that you feel you know, I think 350 number for Intercom is what we've heard as well. Have heard anything about any plans for an exit soon or do you think they continue to build out this Fin bot for a while? How soon do you think consolidation begins in the industry?

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Expert 00:15:17

You mean whether Intercom would IPO or seek some other expert? Is that your question?

Client 00:15:24

How soon do you think that would happen?

Expert 00:15:26

I'm speculating, but I don't think that's this year. I think it might happen next year. 2027 I think would be more likely for getting ready for that. If Salesforce make them an offer, I'm sure they'll consider it. I don't know exactly what the growth rate has been.

From their perspective if they're doing relatively well, I think **they want to lock in a solid three years of growth**, then they can either IPO. They've got a track record that they can position an exit. If they try and do that, they'll still have that iffy period in 2024.

Client 00:15:57

Perfect. Thank you for your time. This was very helpful.

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